for the afternoon in the Shah Zeman Bagh, where the fruit trees were so thickly planted ‘that the sun could not penetrate them at noon, which afforded a cool retreat . . . after luncheon we retired to one of the pavilions which was spread with carpets. Here we spent our time reading the numerous Persian verses written on the walls: most of them alluded to the instability of fortune, some very applicable to the King’s condition.’[44]

Here Elphinstone sat scribbling in his diary, trying to make sense of the Afghan character in all its rich contradictions. ‘Their vices’, he wrote, ‘are revenge, envy, avarice, rapacity, and obstinacy; on the other hand, they are fond of liberty, faithful to their friends, kind to their dependents, hospitable, brave, hardy, frugal, laborious, and prudent.’[45] He was astute enough to note that success in battle in Afghanistan was rarely decided by straightforward military victory so much as by successfully negotiating a path through the shifting patterns of tribal allegiances. ‘The victory is usually decided by some chief going over to the enemy,’ wrote Elphinstone, ‘on which the greater part of the army either follows his example or else takes flight.’[46c]

Shuja was now negotiating for the survival of his regime. William Fraser’s letters home written from Peshawar show how quickly the initial optimism of the Embassy began to give way to anxiety. ‘The reports afloat today are very bad for our poor friend Shuja ul-Mulk,’ wrote Fraser on 22 April. ‘Kabul and Ghazni are both said to be taken by the rebels, and the Kashmerian army is supposed to be defeated. These are the rumours of the town, but generally credited and I fear, too true. So this man is no longer really King, and must fly, at least for a time, or stake the whole on one battle.’[47]

The British were beginning to understand that Afghanistan was no easy place to rule. In the last two millennia there had been only very brief moments of strong central control when the different tribes had acknowledged the authority of a single ruler, and still briefer moments of anything approaching a unified political system. It was in many ways less a state than a kaleidoscope of competing tribal principalities governed through maliks or vakils, in each of which allegiance was entirely personal, to be negotiated and won over rather than taken for granted. The tribes’ traditions were egalitarian and independent, and they had only ever submitted to authority on their own terms. Financial rewards might bring about co-operation, but rarely ensured loyalty: the individual Afghan soldier